

Drowning First Aid Steps

If you witness a drowning incident:

- If you cannot swim or are not trained in water rescue:
 - Do not enter the water.
 - Try to extend a stick or rope, or throw a flotation device to the victim.
- If you are trained and confident in your ability to rescue:
 - Safely remove the victim from the water, then proceed with the following steps:

Assess the drowning victim immediately after water rescue:

1. Place the victim on a firm, flat surface.
2. Check for responsiveness: call their name, tap their shoulders, and watch for any movement or breathing.
3. Open the airway by tilting the head back and lifting the chin (unless a spinal injury is suspected).
4. Check for normal breathing (not just gasping): watch for chest rise for 5–10 seconds.

If the drowning victim is not breathing and unresponsive:

• If you are alone:

1. Start CPR immediately for 2 minutes (about 5 cycles).
2. Call emergency services (997) and resume CPR.

• If someone is with you:

1. One person starts CPR.
2. The other calls emergency services and brings an Automated External Defibrillator (AED) if available.



Adult CPR steps:

1. Open the airway (tilt head back, lift chin).
2. Give 2 rescue breaths (about 1 second each).
3. Perform 30 chest compressions:
 - Position: Center of the chest (lower half of the sternum).
 - Depth: About 5–6 cm (2–2.5 inches).
 - Rate: 100–120 compressions per minute.
4. Repeat 30:2 ratio (30 compressions, 2 breaths).
5. Continue until:
 - Normal breathing returns.
 - EMS arrives.
 - You are physically exhausted.

If an AED is available:

- Use it as soon as possible.
- Move the victim to a dry place and dry the chest before use.
- Follow the device's voice prompts.

If the drowning victim is conscious and breathing:

- Place them in the recovery position.
- Keep them warm.
- Monitor continuously.
- Take them to the hospital even if they appear normal.

If the victim is breathing but unconscious:

- Place in the recovery position.
- Monitor breathing and pulse.
- Call emergency services (997) immediately.

For infants (under 1 year old):

- Use two fingers at the center of the chest (below the nipple line).
- For rescue breaths, cover both nose and mouth.

Important warnings:

- Do not try to remove water from the mouth or press on the chest/abdomen—this is ineffective and can cause injury.
- CPR takes priority over attempts to “expel water.”
- Even if the victim regains consciousness and normal breathing, they must be taken to the hospital for lung evaluation, as delayed complications may occur.